

EVERYTHING THERE IS
By M.G. Vassanji
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Two Pakistani citizens have won Nobel Prizes—Malala Yousafzai, who shared the Peace Prize in 2014 with Kailash Satyarthi, and the great physicist Abdus Salam, who in 1979 became the first scientist from a Muslim country to win a Nobel. Considered the 'father' of Pakistan's programmes in mathematical and theoretical physics and space research, Salam was commemorated on a stamp in 1998, released after Pakistan's first public tests of nuclear weapons in 1998.

But in 1974, five years before he won the Nobel Prize for Physics, Salam quit Pakistan for London in protest, when the constitution was amended to declare Ahmadis, the sect to which he belonged, to be 'non-Muslim'. In *Everything There Is*, the Canadian writer M.G. Vassanji, born in Kenya to Indian parents in 1950, fictionalises Salam's life, imagines what it might have been like to be both a man of science and of faith, even as he comes under attack for both his science and his faith. It is Vassanji's tenth novel and circles a question that underlies all of his considerable catalogue: how to reconcile the gap, the distance between personal and public histories?

On a recent visit to Delhi, as we spoke in his room at the India International Centre (IIC), Vassanji reflected on the "absurdity" of fundamentalism, of doctrinaire insistence and the harm it does to the individual. The unassuming Vassanji wears his erudition like a moth-eaten cardigan. Eminently qualified as Vassanji is to write about a physicist—he has a PhD in nuclear physics from the University of Pennsylvania—it's not physics

BOOKS

Twinned Timelines

Two narratives combine in **Radhika Oberoi's** *Of Mothers and Other Perishables* to create a personal and political story

In her intergenerational novel set in New Delhi, Radhika Oberoi hurls a Molotov cocktail wrapped in a satin scarf embroidered with the words from a consortium of dead poets. It detonates gently. If this were a Pedro Almodóvar film, it would rain down like red rose petals on the marble domes of the Lotus Temple that finds mention in the text.

Oberoi's muse is however Faiz Ahmed Faiz. Like Almodóvar, the poet's preoccupation with the themes of love-death-desire have made him the go-to icon for the oppressed. As the lines of his famously misunderstood poem 'Hum dekhenge' resonate through the text with a certain savage beauty, the words turn into the shreds of ancient velvet and satin worn by the women from the inner city marching to revoke the citizens' bill.

They pool into multitudes. Oberoi calls them the Paperless People. They brave the cold and the intransigence of an authoritarian State with a dignity that is reflected in Oberoi's retelling. They protest for their rights to be recognised

Oberoi's muse is **FAIZ AHMED FAIZ** and the words of his poem 'Hum dekhenge' resonate through the text with savage beauty